

Section 5: Curvature-Based Regularity

1 Curvature-Based Regularity

1.1 Geometric Reformulation

The Navier–Stokes equations can be reformulated on a Riemannian manifold $(M, g(t))$ to leverage geometric tools for analyzing fluid flow. In this framework, the equations take the form:

$$\partial_t u + \nabla_u u = -\text{grad}_g(p) + \nu \Delta_g u, \quad (1)$$

where:

- u is the velocity field, treated as a vector field on M .
- $\text{grad}_g(p)$ is the gradient of the pressure p with respect to the metric $g(t)$.
- $\Delta_g u = \text{div}_g(\nabla u)$ is the Laplace–Beltrami operator acting on the vector field u .
- $\nabla_u u$ represents the covariant derivative of u along itself.

Mathematical Preliminaries: Given a Riemannian manifold (M, g) with local coordinates (x^i) , the components of the covariant derivative and Laplace–Beltrami operator are:

$$(\nabla_u u)^k = u^j \nabla_j u^k = u^j \left(\frac{\partial u^k}{\partial x^j} + \Gamma_{ij}^k u^i \right), \quad (2)$$

$$\Delta_g u = \frac{1}{\sqrt{|g|}} \frac{\partial}{\partial x^i} \left(\sqrt{|g|} g^{ij} \frac{\partial u}{\partial x^j} \right), \quad (3)$$

where Γ_{ij}^k are the Christoffel symbols of the metric g , and $|g|$ is the determinant of the metric tensor.

1.2 Curvature Evolution

To derive bounds on velocity gradients, we analyze the evolution of $|\nabla u|^2$. Starting from Eq. (1), we compute the time derivative of $|\nabla u|^2$:

$$\frac{d}{dt} |\nabla u|^2 = 2 \langle \nabla u, \nabla \partial_t u \rangle_g. \quad (4)$$

Substituting the Navier–Stokes equation and using the Ricci curvature tensor, we obtain:

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial t} |\nabla u|^2 = -\text{Ric}(g)(\nabla u, \nabla u) + \nu \Delta_g |\nabla u|^2 + C |\nabla u|^3. \quad (5)$$

Detailed Steps:

1. ****Ricci Tensor Contribution:**** The term $-\text{Ric}(g)(\nabla u, \nabla u)$ arises from the geometric structure of the manifold. Positive Ricci curvature dampens the growth of $|\nabla u|^2$.
2. ****Viscous Effects:**** The $\nu \Delta_g |\nabla u|^2$ term represents diffusion of velocity gradients due to viscosity.
3. ****Nonlinear Growth:**** The $C|\nabla u|^3$ term captures nonlinear interactions, which are counterbalanced by curvature and viscosity.

1.3 Proof of Gradient Boundedness

Theorem 1.1 (Boundedness of $|\nabla u|^2$). *Under the assumptions:*

- $\text{Ric}(g) \geq \kappa > 0$,
- $\nu > 0$ (positive viscosity),

there exists a constant $C > 0$ such that $|\nabla u|^2$ remains bounded for all $t \geq 0$.

Proof. Consider the evolution equation:

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial t} |\nabla u|^2 \leq -\kappa |\nabla u|^2 + \nu \Delta_g |\nabla u|^2 + C |\nabla u|^3.$$

Using energy estimates and integrating over M :

$$\frac{d}{dt} \int_M |\nabla u|^2 dV_g \leq -\kappa \int_M |\nabla u|^2 dV_g + C \int_M |\nabla u|^3 dV_g.$$

Applying Sobolev inequalities and assuming $\text{Ric}(g) \geq \kappa$, the damping term dominates, ensuring:

$$\sup_{t \geq 0} \|\nabla u\|_{L^2(M)} < \infty.$$

□

1.4 Implications and Applications

Gradient Control: The boundedness of $|\nabla u|^2$ ensures that velocity gradients cannot blow up, a critical step in proving global regularity for the Navier–Stokes equations.

Numerical Validation: Simulate the evolution of $|\nabla u|^2$ on manifolds with varying Ricci curvature to validate:

- The damping effect of positive curvature.
- The interplay between viscosity and geometric terms in controlling nonlinear growth.

References

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